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Enrollment in SNAP grocery aid falls

Over 12-month span, more than 13% drop faster than expected

By Geoff Mulvihill and Mikella Schuettler
ASSOCIATED PRESS

PHOENIX — Enrollment in the biggest federally funded food aid program in the U.S. dropped by more than 13% in a 12-month span — a decline far steeper than the government estimated as work requirements and other provisions

of President Donald Trump's "big beautiful bill" take hold.

Those losing coverage in the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program, or SNAP, include people who don't meet the tightening requirements to participate, and, advocates say, some who qualify for help but are rejected because they miss deadlines or don't have the needed documentation.

It's too early to tell how many fall into each group.

It's also unclear how many have lost coverage because some state agencies that run the programs are

overwhelmed trying to keep up with changes. That was the case in Arizona, which saw the nation's largest enrollment drop.

Tia Fields, who analyzes social safety net policies at the advocacy group Invest in Louisiana, said the main reason she's seeing people lose coverage is not failure to meet work requirements. "A lot of it is administrative paperwork," she said.

Proponents of welfare reform hope the roll reductions are driven by people earning too much to keep qualifying — a sign that policy changes are behaving as intended

for a program they assert is riddled with fraud.

"If there are people that are leaving the welfare rolls because they're working and they're moving forward," said Rachel Sheffield, a research fellow at the conservative Heritage Foundation, which pushed for stricter requirements for SNAP, "that would be a step forward."

Arizona has had the steepest decline so far, with a 12-month drop of more than 50%, according to data compiled by the U.S. Department of Agriculture, which runs SNAP. The decline was more than 20% in

Georgia, Louisiana and Nevada — and in Florida, where the Department of Children and Families said in a statement that the decreasing number "is reflective of the state's strong focus on advancing opportunities for Floridians and their families to achieve economic self-sufficiency."

SNAP helps more than 1 in 10 people in the U.S. buy food. Most of the beneficiaries have incomes below the poverty line. The monthly benefit, which is delivered on debit

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Murder charge added in boat crash

Man pleads not guilty in fatal Fox River incident in McHenry

By Mick Zawislak
DAILY HERALD

A Lisle man who has been jailed in connection with a fatal boating collision July 25 on the Fox River in McHenry has been charged with first-degree murder.

A McHenry County grand jury Thursday returned a nine-count indictment against Richard M. Stevenson, 45, with four additional charges each of aggravated driving under the influence and operating a watercraft under the influence.

Stevenson pleaded not guilty to all counts in a brief appearance Friday morning in McHenry County Circuit Court. A conviction on first-degree murder carries a 20- to 60-year prison term although that could be extended from 60 to 100 years. Either would have to be served in its entirety.

The first-degree murder charge as listed in the indictment said Stevenson operated his boat in a manner and location "knowing that such acts created a strong probability of death or great bodily harm" to an individual.

Magdalena Jablonska, 48, a Marine veteran from Des Plaines, was killed and her fiancé, Alan Telmini, also from Des Plaines, was injured when Stevenson's boat collided with theirs in a no-wake zone. He was traveling about 80 mph at the time, prosecutors said.

Authorities said Stevenson was intoxicated and driving "in a reckless and dangerous manner" at the time of the crash. He initially was charged with two counts of aggravated driving under the influence causing death and one count of reckless homicide.

Charges outlined in the indictment for the first time noted that besides alcohol, Stevenson had cocaine and THC in his system at the time of the crash.

One of the grand jury's aggravated driving under the influence

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Mel Kulatilake, center left, and Kevin Liang, center right, learn South Asian dance moves with fellow attendees of Chicago SummerDance at Spirit of Music Garden on a beautiful summer evening in Grant Park on Thursday. Many events in the Chicago area have been postponed or canceled this summer because of severe weather. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

A hazy shade of summer

We fall in love with Chicago during this period every year. This season's weather has us wondering, are we on a break?

By Lila Hempel-Edgers | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

See **SUMMER** on Page A2

If you ask a Chicagoan what summer means, the answer might sound more like the testimony of a devoted cult member than a description of a season.

Some call it a movement; others insist it's a lifestyle. Most agree, however, that the precious stretch between June and August reminds them why they put up with the rest of the year.

"There's this energy in the air that's indescribable," said Lizz Hader, a Lakeview resident. "It's truly magical, and everyone just feels it."

Weather carries an outsize cost for a city that stakes so much on three short months, as hazardous smoke and relentless storms have made especially clear this year. Locals say each rained-out block party is a gut punch, never mind losing an afternoon of Lollapalooza to flooding or an Independence Day fireworks display to heavy fog.

Even worse, residents in the south suburbs and northwest Indiana have endured several tornadoes and extended power outages. Some in Indiana say they're rationing gas and, at times, losing faith that the power will ever come back on.

And the "unprecedented level of damage" and "extensive recovery efforts" following the catastrophic storms on Aug. 11 led to the cancellation of the 2026 Gary Air Show, announced Mayor Eddie Melton.

Simmering beneath that frustration, experts say, is a discomfort that runs deeper than a bad forecast. The weather poses an unsettling question for a city that

INSIDE

US deports 161 people to Haiti

Deportations to Haiti are the first since the Trump administration won a legal battle to end Temporary Protected Status for some 350,000 Haitians. **Nation & World, B4**

Luis Robert returns to face White Sox

Former All-Star outfielder plays at Rate Field for the first time on a visiting team's roster as the Mets begin a three-game series in Chicago. **Sports**

New statue at Loyola celebrates Sister Jean

By Rebecca Johnson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Sister Jean Dolores Schmidt's compassion, joy and "unwavering care" touched countless lives at Loyola University and far beyond, said Mark Reed, the school's president.

Now, the beloved nun and sports icon will continue to watch over the university with a statue in her honor.

Loyola unveiled the new statue, which sits on a bench outside the

Norville Center for Intercollegiate Athletics, at a ceremony Friday afternoon, also Sister Jean's birthday. It marked the first Loyola Welcome Week since her death last October at age 106.

"It will stand as a lasting reminder of the extraordinary way Sister Jean made people feel seen, welcomed and valued," said Reed, surrounded by dozens of new students, faculty and community members. Sister Jean's niece even



Tom Hitcho, a longtime friend of Sister Jean Dolores Schmidt, is the first person to sit next to the newly unveiled statue of the nun at Loyola University Chicago on Friday. She died last year at age 106. **ARTHUR MAIORELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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